The Beauty Inside

By Catherine Filloux

Cast of Characters (3 women)

YALOVA:**, 14-year-old daughter of **PERI:

***PERI:**, **YALOVA:**'s mother, clever*

***LATIFE:** (pronounced La-tee-fay), lawyer*

Place: *Hospital, southeastern Turkey*

Time: *Present*

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INTRODUCTION

Hundreds, if not thousands, of women are murdered by their families each year in the name of family "honor." It's difficult to get precise numbers on the phenomenon of honor killing; the murders frequently go unreported, the perpetrators unpunished, and the concept of family honor justifies the act in the eyes of some societies. Complicity by other women in the family and the community strengthens the concept of women as property and the perception that violence against family members is a family and not a judicial issue. Females in the family—mothers, mothers-in-law, sisters, and cousins—frequently support the attacks. In The Beauty Inside by Catherine Filloux, a 14-year-old girl in southeastern Turkey is raped by a neighbor and becomes the victim of a botched "honor killing" at the hands of her family. In a terrifying clash of value systems, the girl's traditionalist mother and her Westernized female lawyer struggle with one another to seal her fate. The Beauty Inside by Catherine Filloux.

*[In shadow two figures drag a 14-year-old girl [**YALOVA:**] harshly by her hands and feet. These figures are played by **PERI:** and **LATIFE:**, but should be only dark shadows.]*

YALOVA: He came at night! In the thick dark black, I always saw him eyeing me. "When I went to get the water. Bashed me down. Mud in my mouth. But something worse. So much worse! *[The figures hurl Yalova who is now in rushing water.]* Down there! Tumbling. Her inside me. Myself inside. That's all I can imagine. Too small. For this. Still playing games. With sticks. In

the dark night. "When he comes. Still playing games at night. Till my mother calls me, "Yalova, to bed! My little [*Screaming.]* Yalovaaaa!" *[Lights up on a hospital room. Yalova's mother,* Peri *wearing a head scarf, is trying to drag* Yalova *out of the room.]*

PERI: Yalovaaaa! My little one. Hurry! [*Yalova is bandaged, severely hurt.]*

YALOVA: Mama, they heard me crying. Down the river. The villagers came on their own. I did not call to them!

PERI: I myself will take you to the police.

YALOVA: I didn't tell the doctor, not yet, I promise ...

PERI: Quiet, you will tell them your brothers had nothing to do with it!

YALOVA: But rocks ... I bumped into rocks ... Did it hurt her?

PERI: That's enough! What good are you to us now? [*Latife, a Westernized woman, rushes into the room.]*

LATIFE: What are you doing to her? Get her back into that bed! Are you crazy?

PERI: This is not for you. There are certain things between a mother and daughter that are private.

LATIFE: Put her back in bed or I will get the police. Your sons left her for dead in that canal, Mrs. Bey.

PERI: She dishonored our family. [*Latife struggles with Peri to get the girl, Yalova back into bed. Latife speaks to Yalova.*]

LATIFE: Your two brothers are in jail. And your father, for ordering your killing.

YALOVA: Jail? No. Mama! I'm so sorry! [*Peri changes tactics, helping Yalova into the bed.]*

PERI: Now, now, hush, let me touch you. Does it hurt?

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YALOVA: *[Softly.]* ... Does it hurt her, Mama?

PERI: Shh-shh, lie still, little one. *[To Latife.]* We must pray now. Would you please leave us alone to pray?

LATIFE: I will be just outside the door.

PERI: May I ask you for a small favor? She needs cold water. Would you bring us some? She is ill and my own throat is parched, I have walked so far in the hot sun, my village is very far away ...

LATIFE: I will need to speak to her. Do you understand?

PERI: The water. Please. You are very gracious, we are both unwell, please ...

LATIFE: I'll get water. [*Latife exits. Peri whispers to Yalova so Latife won't hear.]*

PERI: What have you done? Are you mad? *[Shaking her.]* Stupid foolish child!

YALOVA: They are not really in jail, Mama?

PERI: You went to the police. To shame us! You must go back now and say it was a story you invented. It is you who jumped into the canal to save yourself.

YALOVA: ... But he came, the neighbor. In the night. I was playing alone ... Mama ...

PERI: And what is inside you now? Bad, bad girl! [*Peri starts to hit her]*

YALOVA: Stop, Mama. I keep thinking why didn't you call me to bed a little earlier that night ... *[Calling like her mother.]* "Yalovaa ... " [*Peri yanks Yalova back out of the bed.]*

PERI: On the road we will ask for help ...

YALOVA: My head, it is turning ...

PERI: I, who fed you, sang to you when you cried ...

YALOVA: ... turning ...

PERI: What are you worth to us now?

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YALOVA: The walls slipping ...

PERI: We can get no money for you!

YALOVA: What will you do to me? [*Yalova slips to the floor.]* Don't kick me, Mama. *[Shielding her stomach.]* Be careful ...

PERI: I will kill you right here! Then you will see what a curse you have brought on this family. I, all alone, without our men. I SAY GET UP AND WALK.

YALOVA: STOP IT, PLEASE! [*Latife reenters with a pitcher and glass of water.]*

LATIFE: *[Furious.]* Get away from her. Move away from her.

PERI: Let go of me. [*Peri starts to hit Latife]*

LATIFE: Move away from her, stop it!

PERI: I am her mother.

LATIFE: Mother? Kicking her like that.

PERI: What would you know of it?

LATIFE: Move away. *[Throwing water at Peri*] Now sit in that chair and stay until I am finished.

PERI: I will stand.

LATIFE: Stand at a distance.

PERI: Give me some water. [*Latife fills the glass and hands it to her.]* Give her some water. [*Latife kneels next to Yalova*]

LATIFE: Can you hear me? [*Peri starts to approach Yalova again.]* Don't you come closer, go back to the chair.

PERI: She needs a doctor. [*Latife whispers to Yalova*]

LATIFE: You did well to survive-thrown into an irrigation ditch. You floated at least a mile down the canal. [*Yalova whimpers.] [Comfortingly.]* Shh-shh. The

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villagers that rescued you said your cries were so loud, like an animal's. Like an animal they could not recognize. It was not your fault, you did well to tell the police. Right after they threw you in your brothers shot your neighbor ... the man who raped you. Your brothers hoped to kill you too ... No mind can wrap itself around such a thought.

PERI: She is with child. *[Motioning to Yalova's stomach.]* That is what happened. [Latife *looks at Peri, then at Yalova*]

LATIFE: *[To Yalova]* Really? [*Yalova nods.]*

PERI: Stupid girl.

LATIFE: Come, let me help you back into the bed, we need to call the doctor. [*Yalova hallucinates.]*

YALOVA: In the rain time there was silver on the canal.

LATIFE: Stand up, now, that's good.

YALOVA: Like a million fish.

LATIFE: One foot in front of the other.

YALOVA: Sun so bright on the silver, like blinding lights ...

LATIFE: Almost there, you'll rest ...

YALOVA: Don't go in the water, it's dirty, Mama told us ... How could something so beautiful be so dirty, just put a foot in, a toe ...

LATIFE: Let me put the blanket around you. You're not the only one, by far, but when the girl dies the crime disappears. Not with you,

YALOVA: How could something so beautiful be so dirty? [*Peri gets up from the chair.]*

PERI: My water is finished. *[Obsequious.]* I must approach, lady. If it is not

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asking too much. *[To Yalova]* You will go to the police and tell them your brothers and father are not to blame. To restore their honor.

LATIFE: And hers?

PERI: It is not for her to have.

LATIFE: Sometimes I ask myself, did I really come from this country?

PERI: *[Disgusted.]* You left.

LATIFE: No, I live here, in Istanbul. I've been here all my life.

PERI: Istanbul! *[Latife faces Peri*]

LATIFE: I will protect her now.

PERI: And our family? Will you protect us? Without a husband and sons I will become so poor I will survive on handfuls of dirt. All my village: "There goes the dishonored one." *[She spits on Yalova]* Rotten girl.

YALOVA: *[Fainting]* Mama ...

PERI: Don't call to me now.

YALOVA: If only you'd called ...

PERI: Too late, you should have come with me before when I told you to.

YALOVA: If only you'd called me a little earlier to bed that night. *[Imitating her mother, calling.]* "Yalovaaaa!"

PERI: Nonsense! You know what you must do to save us. [Peri *puts her scarf over her head and exits, head bowed against the hot sun ahead. Latife stands a moment, then approaches the hospital bed.]*

LATIFE: My name's Latife Inan. *[She stands looking at Yalova who curls into herself]* There are other girls. Perhaps in your village you heard rumors ... A girl who died because she brought dishonor on her husband, not

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getting permission to go to the movies. Another's throat cut because a love song was dedicated to her on the radio. I will return to the city to prepare your case. We'll place you under security protection. We'll send you somewhere where you'll be safe. When you're better you must agree to testify. Let me get the doctor ...

[*Latife starts to go. Yalova whimpers. Latife sees a little girl, in pain, with a baby inside her.]* When I was a little girl my own mother died. She died in a car crash-if you ever go to Istanbul, you'll see that traffic lights are only there for decoration. They say my mother was the type to stop at them. So ... I was raised by men. My father, two brothers taught me how to excel, study hard, debate at the dinner table, defend my honor. I went to the best university, was lauded by my teachers, lauded especially by my father and my brothers, who always seemed giddy that I, a woman, their creation, succeeded so well, worked out so right.

[*Latife speaks with self-deprecation.]* Now I am a senior lawyer, but there is no place to debate at the dinner table about people like you. Your fate is unthinkable to those who raised me. These men would never understand how in your belly will be your life, yourself; how that woman who walked out the door is still your heroine; how the canal you traveled down is both your road to freedom and the rope to hang you. That silvery mirage you speak of, just out of reach ... I will fight with what I have been given by those men who honor me so highly. For them it's all for common markets, but that's not what it is for me. I will have to fight this their way, the way my own father taught me, for you, Yalova.

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Now let me go get the doctor. *[Back to the rushing canal.]*

YALOVA: And I was in it. Swirling. Diving. Gasping. I was in the canal. More than my toe. But my whole body. I screamed not for me. Because I would rather have drowned than dishonor my mother, My father, my brothers. Whom I loved so much. But I screamed. For her ... *[She is holding a baby in her arms. It is in the future.]* The girl I chose to call Latife. Born into a world of men.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Catherine Filloux
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AWARD HISTORY

2007 National Qualifier – DI - Female
2009 National Qualifier – DI - Female

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